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Reimagining Literary Forms: Twitterature and Instapoetry as Microfiction

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Reimagining Literary Forms: Twitterature and Instapoetry as Microfiction

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Abstract

This paper endeavours to analyse the dynamics of twitter fiction and Instapoetry as post-globalisation phenomena, making a significant impact on a speed-driven world, advocating for readymade enjoyment. With the advent of globalisation, the very nature of readership has undergone a spectacular transformation since the very notion of aesthetics has encroached on the attention span of the readers, rendering readership into viewership. As the market has been globalised, the fervour of mass production and unbridled consumption has enveloped the socio-economic dimension across time and space, reducing every nook and cranny of the society to a single unit measured in terms of money. The field of literature, with the phenomenal surge of science and technology has become subject to a one-dimensional source of entertainment. The onslaught of globalisation has severely affected the very disposition of organic literature, splitting it into splinters, rendering them into products of mass consumption. It also traces the evolution of literature in terms of the genesis of the short stories in the wake of the Industrial Revolution that arrests the idyllic temperament of the world and confines the pleasure of reading to a limited span of hours. From the emergence of the short stories to the development of digital fictions, the paper throws light on the dynamics of this transformation that provides literature with a layer of visuality, rendering it a docile body of entertainment. Moreover, it probes into the aspect of physical and emotional exhaustion which today's readers usually fall prey to, owing to the strenuous effects of globalisation, compelling individuals to confine themselves to a prison of measured enjoyment. In addition, the paper aims at developing the argument regarding the democratisation of the literary space since this digital age enables a polyglossia of voices, proliferating an endless chain of signification. But on the contrary, the very notion of democratisation is posed against certain fundamental questions regarding the depthlessness or the lack of eloquence that slowly creep into the 21st century literature.

Keywords: Aesthetics, Globalisation, Readership, Digitalisation, Mass Consumption.

I

The post-industrial world is marked by the immense growth of science and technology and its impact is witnessed across borders and cultures. Globalization as a complex and unilateral network revolutionizes the societies, economics and cultures around the globe. With the advent of faster internet and seamless communication chain, the world enters a new domain of discourse where social media platforms seem to play a crucial role. This highly digitized discursive space transforms the literary world quite radically, leaning into new forms of representations which comprise blogs, social media posts ranging from poetry to one-liners as a form of expression. With the advent of this new age, the literary space undergoes a radical transformation, breaking away from the old tradition of literature. As the social media platforms emerge with more prominence, the forms of expressions are rendered minimized, opening new democratic avenues to opine, reflecting on the current times.

The literary corpus of the 19th century witnesses the emergence of short stories as a distinct genre. The narratives of the short stories, unlike the structural disposition of a novel, involve complex issues in concise yet impactful ways. As industrialization engulfs Europe, life becomes more complex and tiring, demanding a sense of relief from the toil of everyday existence. At this juncture, short stories appear as a new form of entertainment, serving the pleasure of reading without consuming much time.

With the advent of the twentieth century, the literary world witnessed the emergence of microfiction, by writers such as Walt Whitman, Kate Chopin, and Ambrose Bierce and the rest. Perhaps the best-known microfiction from this time is Ernest Hemingway's six-word long fiction: "For sale: baby shoes, never worn." (The Writing Cooperative). Amy Hempel's "Housewife" is

another fine example of microfiction where she writes, “She would always sleep with her husband and another man in the course of the same day, and then for the rest of the day, for whatever was left to her of that day, she would exploit by incanting, ‘French film, French film.’” (Hempel, 004) Another prominent example of micro-fiction which materializes the concept of ‘twist’ is “Knock” by Fredrick Brown. In his open-ended fiction, Brown writes, “The last man on Earth sat alone in a room. There was a knock at the door.” (Notability)

II

Microfiction, generally, refers to a very short narrative, usually somewhere between 750-1000 words. Holly Howitt-Dring in her article, “Making micro meanings: reading and writing microfiction”, writes that the haibun, a blend of prose and *haiku*¹ poetry developed in 17th century Japan, shares similarities with microfiction owing to its concise form. This form, according to her, influences contemporary *ketai*² fiction comprising brief stories originally crafted for text messages in late 20th century Japan resembling a close affinity with “mobile-phone-fiction” or “thumb novels, popular in the West. Adding more to her observation, she writes that *ketai* fiction also inspires Twitter Lit, ultra -short stories limited to Twitter’s character count and often tagged with #vss (very short story). (2)

Howitt-Dring further writes in her article, “As the century developed, microfiction came alive in the hands of Kafka, Borges and other literary heavyweights. No wonder microfiction has grown since – not in size, but in popularity.” (5), paving way for nanofiction comprising a word limit of 200-300 words. This dynamic transformation has provided literature with a greater flexibility, inspiring new writers of a post-global digital world to ink their thoughts using social media as a platform. The recent forms of digital fiction include Twitterature or Twitter Fiction which refers to an original, self-contained work of fiction published by a Twitter user within a

limit of 140 characters. Arjun Basu, a prominent writer of Twitter Fiction, posts microstories in the form of tweets branded as "Twisters" (Arjun Basu). The twitter author gains a wide range of readership with the publication of his bite-sized, fictional tweets like: "They tolerated the ennui of their jobs, bought off by promises of spectacular riches sometime in the future. At retirement, they bought guns" (Six Pixels of Separation). The first Twitter novels, both tweeted in 2007 and 2008, are said to be *Small Places* by Nicholas Belardes and *The Good Captain* by Jay Bushman. *Small Places* tells the story of a mundane, corporate life of a man in California and *The Good Captain* is a sci-fi retelling of Herman Melville's *Benito Cereno*.

With the emergence of experimental writing, the new age of digital fiction witnesses the development of yet another sub-genre that is, Instapoetry. Contemporary poets and writers experiment with the very form, structure and content of not just short stories but of poetry as well. Instagram is seemingly transformed into a literary space of self-expression where the Instapoets are primarily concerned with keeping the style of poetry usually short, direct, approachable, aesthetically pleasing, sometimes didactic, open-ended and reflexive with common-place themes of everyday living. These poems are often portrayed with images attuned to the theme and are often without rhyme schemes or meter. Instapoetry comprises bite-sized verses concerning political and social subjects such as immigration, domestic violence, sexual assault, love, culture, feminism, gun violence, war, racism, LGBTQ rights and others. The Indian born Canadian writer Rupi Kaur is one of the leading figures in the context of Instapoetry. Kaur's work is simplistic in language and explores the issues concerning her south Asian identity, immigration, femininity, trauma and healing. Her first collection of poems "Milk and Honey" (2014) gained commercial success followed by her second and third collection titled "The Sun and Her Flowers" (2017) and "Home Body" (2020), respectively. She states that she has been writing for "that brown woman in

Brampton...who is just trying to live, survive, get through her day.”(Literary Hub). She writes in “Milk and Honey”:

you tell me to quiet down cause
my opinions make me less beautiful
but i was not made with a fire in my belly
so i could be put out
i was not made with a lightness on my tongue
so i could be easy to swallow
i was made heavy
half blade and half silk
difficult to forget and not easy
for the mind to follow
(Milk and Honey, 30)

Amanda Lovelace is another remarkable Instapoet, whose collection of poems “The Princess Saves Herself in This One” comprises all the trademarks of Instapoetry– emotional vulnerability, shorter lines and directness of the content, stirring feelings of unease in the reader. She writes:

the princess i was born
a little bookmad
i could be found stroking
the spines of my books
while i sat locked alone
inside my tower bedroom.

all the while, I hoped my books
would spill their exquisite words
over the lush green carpet
so i could collect them one by one
& savor them like
berries inside my mouth
– forever a collector of words

(The Princess Saves Herself in This One)

Carla Raguseo in her work *Twitter Fiction: Social Networking and Microfiction in 140 characters* highlights the very aspect of ultra-minimalist narratives and how these narratives circulating on the social media platforms blur the distinction between reading and interpreting of texts. (4) The encroachment of technology in the fields of art and literature has rendered it accessible to viewers across borders and cultures. These kinds of texts are brief and often end on a cliffhanger note, demanding active and immediate participation of its readers. These ‘writerly texts’³ of this digital age, therefore, enable proliferation of meanings, effectuating an endless cycle of signification within the literary space. The active participation on the part of the readers across cultures ensures the democratization of the literary space, where a text is open to thousands of interpretations. A ‘polyglossia of voices’⁴ around the text surpasses the authorial voice and the readers find themselves engaged in the complex networking of meaning making. This democratic approach to literature, however, leads to the fragmentation of literary texts. The once holistic field of literature becomes fragmented, raising a fundamental question: is the very discourse of literature losing its eloquence and value? There is a growing concern that the multitude of voices, while diverse, may become overly noisy, turning this chaotic democratization into a compromise of

literature's depth and splendor.

III

With the advent of the digital space, the very nature of aesthetics has encroached on the attention span of the readers, rendering readership into viewership. The physical and mental exhaustion which the readers usually fall prey to, owing to the strenuous effect of globalization, compels individuals to confine themselves to a prison of measured enjoyment. In a corporatized world, readers often suffer from brain fatigue and therefore, the opiate 'reel fiction' acts as the easy source of pleasure. In a world of scroll culture, the dopamine effect of the 30s readymade enjoyment provided to the viewers in the form of nanofiction and nanopoeetry, gains enormous commercial success.

The onslaught of globalization severely affects the disposition of organic literature, rendering them into products of mass consumption. Art and literature in a post-industrial world, owing to mass production, loses their authenticity and gets represented by means of monetary value only. This mercantilization of art and literature results in further aestheticisation of the literary and cultural space where the poets and writers put more emphasis on viewership over readership. Rupi Kaur in her Instagram posts associate her brief poems with a number of images to further embellish the text thereby, perforating the age-old literary tradition with such experimentations.

The dynamic evolution of literature in the post-global era brings forth both intriguing possibilities and profound concerns, as the paper interrogates through the lenses of 'Twitterature' and 'Instapoetry.' This critical inquiry reveals a complex interplay between globalization, technology, and artistic expression, where literature has transformed from a traditionally immersive and expansive experience to a concise, visually driven medium of mass consumption.

While these experimental forms democratize literary spaces and provide accessibility to diverse voices, they simultaneously risk eroding the very depth and splendour that have long defined literary art.

IV

The present paper, therefore, effectively explores how globalization has altered literary aesthetics and consumption patterns. In a world increasingly dominated by fast-paced living and ‘scroll culture’, digital literature such as Twitter fiction and Instapoetry emerges as a response to shortened attention spans and the demand for instant gratification. Arjun Basu's "Twisters" and Rupi Kaur's bite-sized, image-laden verses encapsulate this phenomenon, representing literature's adaptation to the constraints of social media platforms. These works are emblematic of a new literary landscape where brevity and accessibility reign supreme, reaching an audience that might otherwise eschew traditional literary forms.

However, this shift raises critical questions about the commodification and aestheticisation of literature. As the paper highlights, the commercialization of literature has turned art into a product for mass consumption, reducing its essence to fleeting entertainment and measurable monetary value. The works of Instapoets like Kaur, though lauded for their emotional relatability and socio-political relevance, are often critiqued for their mediocrity and lack of linguistic or structural complexity. This simplification risks fostering a shallow literary culture, where profound exploration of themes and nuanced artistic expression are sacrificed for virality and visual appeal.

Moreover, the paper astutely addresses the implications of technology's encroachment into literary spaces, engaging a polyglossia of voices. The democratic openness of digital literature invites endless interpretations and participatory engagement from readers, dissolving the traditional hierarchical relationship between author and audience. While this democratization

enriches literature with diverse perspectives, it also fragments its coherence and integrity. The tension between reader-driven interpretation and the preservation of artistic intentionality emerges as a central concern in this context.

The fragmentation of traditional literary structures, as seen in the ultra-minimalist narratives of Twitterature and Instapoetry, challenges established norms of literary value. The paper raises compelling questions about whether this splintering has rendered literature garrulous and chaotic, potentially undermining its eloquence and cultural significance. This observation invites reflection on whether the democratization of literary spaces, while inclusive and liberating, might also dilute the essence of literature as a medium of deep intellectual and emotional engagement.

Furthermore, the paper critiques the aestheticisation of literature in the digital age, where visual and multimedia elements often accompany written texts. While this integration can enhance interpretative possibilities, it also risks overshadowing the textual content, reducing literature to an accessory in a visually driven cultural economy. The works of Rupi Kaur exemplify this trend, where images and minimalistic verses create a consumable aesthetic that resonates with contemporary audiences but often lacks the layered complexity of traditional poetry.

V

In conclusion, the paper presents a nuanced critique of the post-global literary landscape, acknowledging the innovative potential of digital forms like Twitterature and Instapoetry while lamenting their limitations. These forms represent a double-edged sword, democratizing access to literature and fostering creative experimentation but also raising concerns about the commodification, fragmentation, and potential superficiality of contemporary literary art. The interrogation of these digital forms invites broader discussions about the future of literature in an

age of globalization and technological saturation. As literature continues to evolve, the challenge lies in balancing accessibility and innovation with the preservation of its intellectual, cultural, and aesthetic integrity. This critical reflection underscores the urgency of re-evaluating the values and priorities of literary production and consumption in the 21st century.

Notes

1. Haiku is a traditional form of Japanese poetry, known for its simplicity, brevity, and deep connection to nature. It typically consists of three lines with a syllable pattern of 5-7-5. It often features images from nature, capturing moments of beauty, change, or transience. This focus reflects the Japanese aesthetic of *mono no aware* (the awareness of the impermanence of things).
2. Ketai is a term used to refer to mobile phone literature or cell phone literature, particularly in Japan. It originated in the early 2000s as a new form of storytelling that took advantage of mobile phones' text-messaging capabilities. The word *ketai* means "mobile phone" in Japanese, and the literature created on these devices is often short, direct, and adapted to the constraints of texting, such as character limits.
3. The term "writerly text" originates from Roland Barthes's influential book *S/Z* (1970), where he distinguishes between readerly texts (*lisible*) and writerly texts (*scriptible*). A writerly text invites active participation from the reader, encouraging them to produce meanings rather than passively consuming a fixed narrative.
4. The polyglossia of voices refers to the presence and interaction of multiple voices, perspectives, or linguistic styles within a single text or discourse. The term is closely associated with Mikhail Bakhtin, particularly his concept of heteroglossia, which explores

the coexistence of diverse languages or social discourses in a literary work.

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